

Won't that start a lot of arguments?

ANSWER: I've counseled many couples who tried to "wing" it for a while. Unfortunately, many of them got shot down before they learned to fly. These couples didn't plan to get into debt, and most of them didn't overtly waste their money. They didn't go out and buy a Mercedes or take vacations in Hawaii. They got into debt through a lack of control over things like clothes, washing machines, lawn mowers, and drapes for their homes. The problem was usually too much too soon.

It wasn't what they bought so much as when they bought it. Credit doesn't avoid a decision that you can't afford something yet. It allows you to buy it and then discover that you couldn't afford it. A budget requires that all purchases be preplanned and all credit be offset by monthly income. In other words, you can't buy something that you can't afford to pay for. If a budget restricts your freedom, you probably have too much freedom. Every couple needs a budget, newlyweds especially. Never start out a marriage without knowing where your money is coming from and where it's going.

QUESTION 3. Should we tithe on our net or gross?

We know we should tithe, but should we tithe on our gross or on our net income?

ANSWER: I believe you can answer this question best by praying about it together. Whether you tithe on your net or your gross really depends on your conviction from God. Remember that giving is nothing more than an outside expression of an inside spiritual conviction. If you believe that God owns everything, give God the first part of everything. If you believe that God owns your net, then give from your net.

The amount of the tithe is not important to God; He owns everything. The amount is important to us. The tithe, given as a testimony, reaps a great harvest because it is the seed we plant in God's garden. God is able to take our tithe and multiply it.